not his key condition for a settlement. It was Kennedy, not Khrushchev, who believed that giving up the American missiles in Turkey was the sine qua non for a peaceful resolution of the crisis, and it was not the Soviet but the American media—Walter Lippmann—that discussed such a proposal first. That particular issue aside, Kennedy was de facto accepting Khrushchev's proposal of October 26. He wrote about "weapons" rather than about the "Soviet specialists" who serviced them, but that was what Khrushchev had in mind anyway.

There was, however, one caveat that did not appear in Khrushchev's offer—the United Nations' supervision of the withdrawal of the missiles. Khrushchev already knew about that proposal from the report of his KGB chief in Washington, Aleksandr Feklisov, who had allegedly received it from John A. Scali, an ABC correspondent with direct connection to the State Department and the White House. Khrushchev did not know, however, that in an apparent attempt to upstage Dobrynin as a confidential channel to the White House, Feklisov proposed a deal to Scali that no one in the Soviet leadership ever authorized him to offer, namely, to agree to the removal of the missiles under UN supervision. Kennedy considered that to be Khrushchev's position, and Khrushchev now had no choice but to believe that it was Kennedy's.[10]

Khrushchev was ready for action. After the shooting down of the U-2, he did not think that he was in a position to reject UN supervision of the withdrawal process. With reports from Havana suggesting that Cuba and the world in general were moving rapidly toward war, and Kennedy's letter offering a way out, he was prepared to accept Kennedy's official offer. He seemed as frightened of impending war as the US president. They were both eager to accept whatever they believed to be the other side's latest offer. Now it was Khrushchev's turn.

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KHRUSHCHEV CALLED A MEETING OF THE PARTY PRESIDIUM for noon at a villa in Novo-Ogarevo outside Moscow. Anatoly Dobrynin later recalled that Khrushchev had moved the venue from the Kremlin to Novo-Ogarevo once